Staff Ride to Vietnam

Developing a broader understanding of the Vietnam War, COIN, and patterns of conflict

by 1stLt Alexander M. Corbett

From 1 October to 11 October 2016, a detachment of nine NCOs and four lieutenants from Company K, 3d Bn, 3d Marines, went to Vietnam on a staff ride to study the history of conflicts in that country. Over the course of this trip, the Marines learned many valuable tactical, operational, and strategic lessons. The cost of this PME (professional military education) trip was largely offset by a generous contribution of $5,200 from the Marine Corps Association & Foundation. This article summarizes the PME trip and includes some lessons learned.

We chose Vietnam as the site for a battle study because our battalion fought there from 1965 to 1969. Battles near the famed "Rockpile," the hills north of Khe Sanh and along Route 9, put 3/3 on the map. This organizational history, Vietnam's embryonic rapprochement with the United States, its strategic importance in the growing South China Sea disputes, and its rapid modernization efforts made Vietnam the ideal choice for Marines to study a broad spectrum of political-military affairs.

Prior to departure, all Marines attending the staff ride read *Phase Line Green* by Nicholas Warr, *No Shining Armor* by Otto Lehrack, and *The Village* by Bing West.[1] The purpose of these background readings was to ensure that all attendees had a solid framework of references to draw from during the trip. Because of this, tours and sites visited during the staff ride had deeper context. On a more personal level, *No Shining Armor* contained numerous first-person accounts of our battalion's fights in the areas we visited, making our site visits much more poignant.



Marines of 3/3 in front of the Rockpile. *(Photo by author.)*

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To supplement these books, and to add diversity to our teaching and learning methods, the lieutenants on the staff ride created classes on various aspects of Vietnamese history and culture. These classes were the first event of each day, setting the tone for tours and sites visits. The subjects of these classes ranged a variety of topics, including Ancient Vietnam; Colonialism in Vietnam; WWII in Vietnam; the French-Indochina War; U.S. Involvement; Vietnam 1975–Present; the Battle of Hue City; Operation STARLITE; and the Battles of Khe Sanh, the Rockpile, and Dong Ha. These classes provided a breadth of military and cultural understanding for the conflicts we studied.

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Securing funding from the Marine Corps Association & Foundation was critical to the success of a trip of such scope. This allowed far better learning opportunities and flexibility for the trip, thereby increasing the knowledge and camaraderie gained by the attendees. To take advantage of this program, contact the Commander's Forums department at the Marine Corps Association & Foundation. They typically set up the events for units, so if there is already a trip plan, battle sites, and tours identified, they will simply donate a gift to facilitate your written plan. The process for this is straightforward but can take some time.

Upon landing in Hanoi, the Marines stayed in the "Old Quarter," a bustling scene of labyrinthine alleys, aggressive street vendors, and overpowering smells. The architecture is similar to what can be seen in Haiti, New Orleans, and presumably every other tropical region the French occupied during their second colonial era. The first site we visited was the Hanoi Hilton, the infamous prison complex in Hanoi. It was here that French authorities detained the insurgents who eventually became the founders of the Viet Minh. During the so called "American War" of the 1960s and 70s, American pilots were interned here to await prisoner exchanges. Their treatment is widely known to have violated international norms for treatment of prisoners of war. In the Hanoi Hilton, however, the pictures and placards document happy and smiling American POWs, eager to "apologize" for their "crimes" against the Vietnamese people.

As Hanoi is a historic and politically important city, the Marines ensured to visit as many museums as possible. The Museum of the Revolution, the B-52 Museum, the Ho Chi Minh Museum, and the Vietnam Military History Museum were all very informative and interesting. In particular, the B-52 Museum was quite fascinating. It memorialized the North Vietnamese air defense units that fought American bombers during Operation LINEBACKER II. The statistics of how many aircraft were shot down vary widely, depending on which nation is counting. Of interest is the wreckage of the B-52s that were shot down and recovered by the Vietnamese. These, along with captured Hueys and vehicles at the Military History Museum, were treated like old fashioned war trophies. In a bizarre twist, virtually every bar in Hanoi serves a "B52 shot," a foul tasting, syrupy, flaming shooter. This, coupled with old propaganda posters picturing former President Richard M. Nixon as a malicious war criminal, show how the Vietnamese psyche and culture has really attached itself to their defensive performance against our bombing efforts in the 1970s.

After a couple days in Hanoi, we went on a day trip to the Perfume Pagoda in the My Duc District. This maze-like complex of temples and shrines is the site of the longest annual religious festival in Vietnam, which attracts hundreds of thousands of worshippers. The religious importance of the site dates back over 2,000 years. The first structures are dated to the 16th century, with more complex sites being added regularly for the past 300 years.

The following morning, the Marines set out for a two-day trip to Ha Long Bay. This UNESCO World Heritage Site in northeast Vietnam is a popular destination as its raw physical beauty and history are significant. We successfully tried our hands at squid fishing, and a kayak paddling trip among and under the limestone karsts in the bay was fascinating. A visit to a local fishing village showed how the indigenous populace survived.

We left Ha Long Bay, rode back to Hanoi, and immediately went to the train station. We boarded an overnight train to Hue City, where Marines fought during the 1968 Tet Offensive. In Hue, our first stop was at the street known to Marines as "Phase Line Green." Today, this busy thoroughfare shows no resemblance to the bullet ridden disaster that Nicholas Warr describes in the book he named after it.

Taking an opportunity to see the surrounding countryside, we signed on for a tour with Cafe on Thu Wheels, a small tour organizing company in the new part of Hue. Our first stop was the remains of the Khe Sanh combat base, the site of the famous siege in 1968. The mortar pits and some of the trenches were still there, memorializing the brutal battle. The air strip has been turned into a coffee plantation. Off to the side are various pieces of unexploded ordnance set up as a display near a captured Bell helicopter. In the center of the remains of the combat base stands an A-frame structure—the museum detailing the battle. Inside are pictures and relics that Americans are unfamiliar with, along with the bizarre statistics that we became inured to seeing at every war memorial. It seems unlikely, for example, that over 20 American naval vessels were sunk in the mountainous environs of the Battle of Khe Sanh.

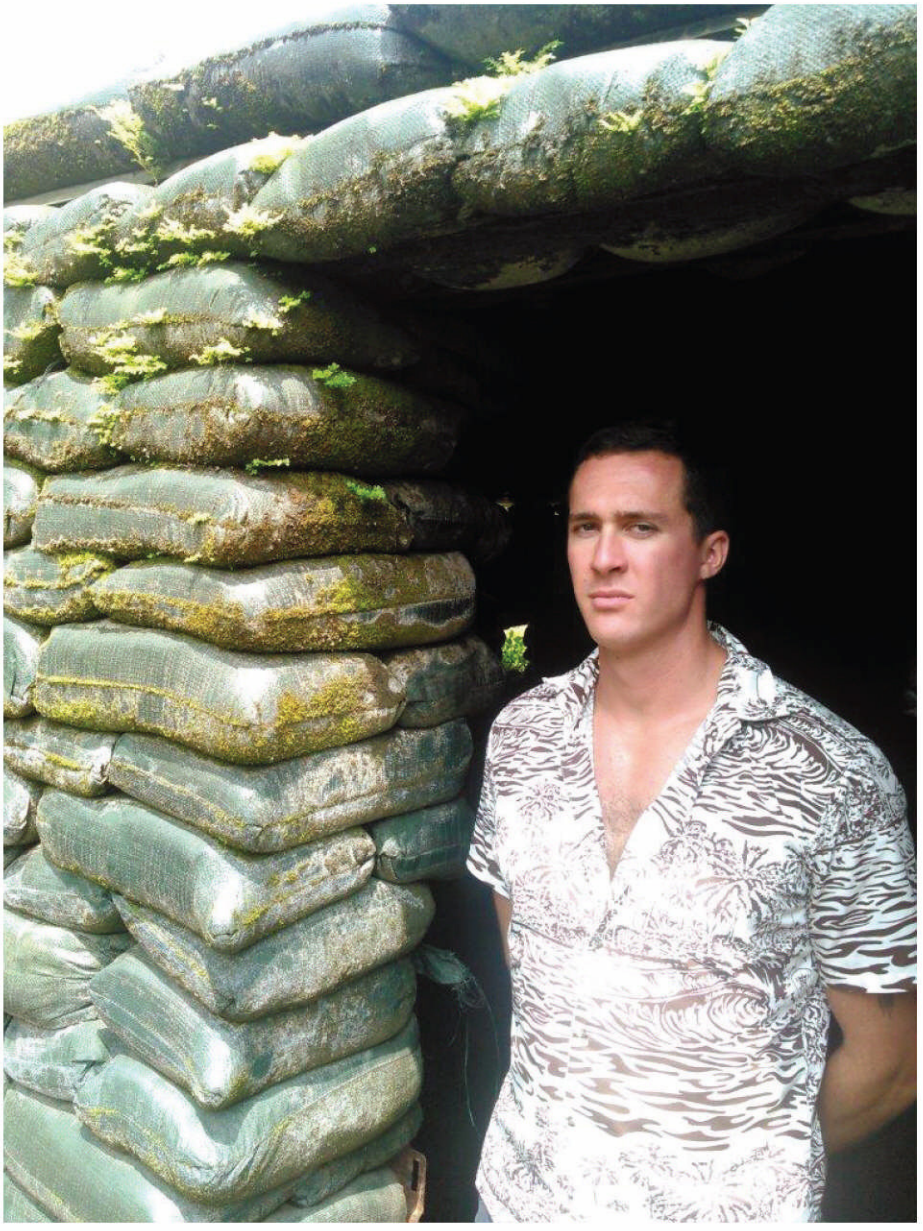
Inside the museum, the pictures and narrative driven are very different from what we as Americans have seen presented from the Vietnam War. There were close ups of Marines being shelled by mortars, wounded Americans, and C-130s under fire. These pictures were used to support the story of the "patriotic victory" of the North Vietnamese Army at Khe Sanh, even though they

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ultimately withdrew from the field of battle.

The next stop was the Vinh Moc tunnel complex in Quang Tri Province. These tunnels housed over 100 Vietnamese civilians, with some tunnels more than 50 feet below ground. The stifling air and low ceilings must have made day-to-day life particularly unpleasant. There were storage rooms, a hospital room, and a birthing room all dug out of the dirt. Some caves, like those for medical treatment, were dug closer to ventilation holes in order to get fresh air to sick civilians. Our tour guide explained how the villagers of this region slept underground every night for over 10 years in order to avoid the conflict.

The last stop on our tour was Dong Ha, the site of the bridge destroyed by then-Capt John Walter Ripley. Capt Ripley, Company Commander, Lima 3/3, 1966–67, returned to Vietnam in 1972 as an air-naval gunfire liaison officer, assisting an Army of the Republic of Vietnam battalion in its combat operations against the NVA (North Vietnamese Army). He earned a Navy Cross for crawling hand-over-hand under the bridge, constantly under fire, emplacing over 500 pounds of explosives, and ultimately destroying the bridge. This halted the NVAs Easter Offensive of 1972 and prevented the fall of Saigon for another three years. The old road to the bridge is now an informal market.



The author in an American bunker, Khe Sanh Combat Base. *(Photo by author.)*

Following our extensive DMZ tour, we boarded the train in Hue and took another overnight ride to Hanoi. The views from the train were picturesque—we passed through rice farming villages with water buffaloes, palm trees, and many Communist Party billboards.

The trip to Vietnam was highly informative and allowed all the Marines to grow professionally. Whether visiting the B-52 Museum and seeing the remains of American bombers shot down during Operations LINEBACKER I and II, exploring the abandoned fortifications of Khe Sanh, climbing through the Vinh Moc tunnels, or walking Phase Line Green in Hue City, infantrymen of 3/3 were able to put sights and sounds to the battle stories they have grown up on. They were surprised and humbled to learn how much the average Vietnamese citizen is amicable toward the United States and how they fundamentally distrust China and its aggressive regional aspirations.

The lessons these Marines learned on their staff ride will stay with them for their lifetimes as it was a truly high-fidelity experience. Those who remain in the Marine Corps and become sergeants major or colonels will have a broader and deeper understanding of the Vietnam conflict, counterinsurgency, and patterns of conflict in Southeast Asia. That understanding will allow better decisions and ultimately save the lives of Marines in their charge. This is what the Marine Corps Association & Foundation provides with their Commander's Forum gifts.

Note

1. See Nicholas Warr, *Phase Line Green: The Battle for Hue,* (Annapolis, MD: Naval Institute Press, 2013); Otto Lehrack, *No Shining Armor: The Marines at War in Vietnan: An Oral History,* (Lawrence, KS: University of Kansas Press, 1992); and Bing West, *The Village,* (New York: Pocket Books, re-printed 2013).

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